



The Forward Deployed Engineer Playbook

The field guide to breaking in, getting hired, shipping real software, and building the teams behind it.

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From your first deployment to building the team.

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ABOUT THIS PLAYBOOK

Educational guidance, not a substitute for employer policies, security requirements, contractual terms, or professional financial advice. Examples, numbers, and weights throughout are illustrative. Adapt them to your organization.

INTRODUCTION

The last mile is where the real work begins.

Building impressive technology has never been easier. Getting it into production, embedded into a customer's workflows, delivering value, and keeping it running? That's a different story. That's where Forward Deployed Engineers come in.

An FDE sits at the intersection of software engineering, product development, customer delivery, and business operations.

01 They don't just build features. They figure out what actually needs building.

02 They don't just run demos. They get systems into production.

03 They don't disappear when the integration gets complicated.

The best FDEs combine technical depth with commercial awareness, customer empathy, urgency, and an unusual tolerance for ambiguity. But the role is still evolving. Two companies can advertise the same FDE title and expect very different things.

This playbook exists to help establish and share the craft. Whether you're a software engineer looking to transition into FDE, a new hire preparing for your first deployment, a senior engineer improving your craft, or a founder building a deployment organization, this is your starting point.

No fluff. No pretending every deployment goes perfectly. Just the principles, frameworks, and practical tools that help people build things that actually work.

OUR OPERATING PHILOSOPHY



And when you find something that works, make it easier for the next person.

CHAPTER 01

Getting into FDE

You don't need the title to start doing the work.

Forward Deployed Engineering isn't a single career path. Great FDEs can come from software engineering, data engineering, infrastructure, technical consulting, solutions engineering, or early-stage startups.

The common thread isn't your job title. It's your ability to own technical problems in unfamiliar environments and turn them into working solutions.

FDE is an ownership model, not simply a programming language or a job title.

The five skills you need

- | | |
|----|--|
| 01 | Strong software engineering fundamentals. Be comfortable building and debugging applications, not just solving algorithm questions. Know APIs, databases, authentication, testing, deployment, and basic system architecture. |
| 02 | Learning speed. You will regularly encounter systems, codebases, industries, and technologies you've never used before. Your ability to learn quickly matters. |
| 03 | Customer communication. You need to explain technical trade-offs to nontechnical stakeholders, ask good questions, and push back professionally when necessary. |
| 04 | Product judgment. Understand why the customer needs the solution, how people will use it, and which features actually matter. |
| 05 | Ownership. You don't wait for someone to write a perfect ticket. You investigate, establish priorities, and drive the work forward. |

How to break in without previous FDE experience

Build evidence, not just a résumé. Create a portfolio project that simulates a real customer deployment.

EXAMPLE BRIEF

A mid-sized insurance company processes hundreds of inbound documents daily. Build a system that extracts relevant information, routes exceptions to an employee, and records an audit trail.

Don't stop once the prototype works. Show that you can:

- 1 Define the customer's problem and success criteria.
- 2 Design a working system with realistic data.
- 3 Connect an API, database, and user interface.
- 4 Handle errors, authentication, and edge cases.
- 5 Deploy it somewhere accessible.
- 6 Write documentation and explain operational trade-offs.
- 7 Measure its performance against a baseline.

Publish a short case study showing your technical decisions, trade-offs, mistakes, and what you'd improve. That's considerably more useful than another chatbot demo.

Your 30-day transition plan

WEEK 1	Study five FDE job descriptions and identify the gaps in your technical knowledge.
WEEK 2	Build a customer-facing prototype around one concrete workflow.
WEEK 3	Productionize the strongest slice with tests, logging, evaluation, documentation, and deployment automation.
WEEK 4	Present the solution as if you were speaking to a customer's CTO. Explain the business problem, architecture, cost, risks, and rollout plan.

THE TAKEAWAY

Stop asking how to get an FDE title. Start demonstrating that you can do FDE work.

CHAPTER 02

Interviewing

Being a great engineer isn't enough if you can't explain how you think.

FDE interviews differ across companies, but they typically evaluate a combination of technical engineering, structured problem-solving, learning ability, and customer judgment. Some organizations emphasize coding and systems design. Others introduce ambiguous customer scenarios, unfamiliar technologies, or practical deployment exercises. You need to prepare for both.

The five areas to master

01 Coding and engineering fundamentals

Expect exercises involving APIs, data structures, databases, debugging, or existing codebases. Practice writing understandable, maintainable code while explaining your decisions.

02 Problem decomposition

You'll receive a vague problem and need to turn it into an executable plan.

THE PROMPT

A logistics company wants to reduce delivery delays using AI. How would you approach this?

WEAK CANDIDATE

Immediately proposes a model.

STRONG CANDIDATE

Starts asking questions:

- | | |
|--|---|
| ? What does "delay" mean operationally? | ? How are delays measured today? |
| ? Who owns dispatch decisions? | ? What constraints must the solution satisfy? |
| ? What systems hold vehicle, route, and delivery data? | ? What is the smallest useful intervention? |
| ? Where are the biggest delays occurring? | |

Only then do they propose an architecture.

03 System design and integration

Prepare to discuss:

- API design and integration patterns.
- SQL, data pipelines, and event-driven systems.
- Authentication, authorization, and security.
- Cloud infrastructure and deployment.
- Reliability, latency, cost, and observability.
- AI evaluations and failure handling, where relevant.

04 Customer judgment

Can you disagree with someone paying your company without damaging the relationship? Can you separate what they want from what they need? Can you communicate an uncomfortable delivery update?

05 Ownership and execution

Interviewers want evidence that you've driven complex work forward without perfect information. Prepare examples of ambiguous projects, production failures, difficult stakeholders, and decisions made under time pressure.

The FDE problem-solving framework

Use this structure for open-ended technical and customer scenarios.

01 **Clarify.** Who is the user? What's broken? Why now?

02 **Quantify.** What's the baseline, and what improvement matters?

- | | |
|----|--|
| 03 | Constrain. What are the data, security, infrastructure, budget, and time limitations? |
| 04 | Decompose. Break the problem into independently testable components. |
| 05 | Prioritize. Identify the smallest valuable solution. |
| 06 | Design. Propose architecture and discuss trade-offs. |
| 07 | Validate. Explain how you'll test success, handle failures, and roll out. |
| 08 | Communicate. Summarize your recommendation, risks, and next steps. |

Don't just narrate the technology. Narrate your judgment.

Five practice interview questions

- 1 A customer wants an AI agent to automate a workflow, but can't explain the current process. What do you do first?
- 2 You've inherited an unfamiliar repository and have 90 minutes to fix a production issue. Where do you start?
- 3 Your largest customer wants a custom feature that the product team doesn't support. How do you respond?
- 4 Your proof of concept works on test data but fails on real customer data. Walk through your investigation.
- 5 The customer wants production by Friday. You believe the system isn't safe to deploy. What do you say?

What exceptional candidates do differently

- They ask clarifying questions without needing constant direction.
- They know how to simplify.
- They explain what they don't know.
- They make decisions with incomplete information while acknowledging the consequences.
- They understand that writing code is only one part of delivering an outcome.

THE TAKEAWAY

Show how you make decisions, not just how quickly you can solve a problem.

CHAPTER 03

Your first 30 days

Your first job isn't to impress everyone. It's to understand where value gets created.

Starting an FDE role can be overwhelming. You're learning the product, customer environments, internal systems, deployment processes, and frequently an entirely new industry.

Resist the temptation to immediately start building. Your first month should establish the context, relationships, and technical confidence required to own delivery.

DAYS 1-7

Understand the environment

- Get your development environment working.
- Understand the product architecture and major limitations.
- Review previous deployments, successful and unsuccessful.
- Shadow an experienced FDE on customer calls.
- Understand how deployments are scoped and prioritized.
- Learn how incidents, security reviews, and escalations work.
- Meet Engineering, Product, Sales, Support, and your deployment leadership.

DELIVERABLE

A one-page map of the product, customer journey, and deployment workflow. It should answer three questions:

- 1 What does the customer actually buy?
- 2 What usually prevents them from getting value?
- 3 Who helps remove those blockers?

DAYS 8-14

Build something real

Take on a limited technical task in a real or realistic environment. Ideally, choose something involving an API, integration, data workflow, or customer-specific configuration. You should start:

- Reading production code.
- Making small, reviewed changes.

- Understanding the deployment pipeline.
- Practicing debugging with logs and traces.
- Learning testing and rollback procedures.
- Participating in customer technical discussions.

DELIVERABLE

Your first reviewed and tested contribution, along with documentation explaining what changed.

DAYS 15–21

Own a small problem

Find a contained workstream that you can manage with oversight. That might mean fixing an integration, improving a workflow, building a small feature, or investigating a recurring customer issue. Write a technical plan, confirm success criteria, communicate progress, and surface blockers early.

DELIVERABLE

One completed piece of work with an identified owner, acceptance criteria, and user impact.

DAYS 22–30

Demonstrate ownership

By the end of your first month, you should be able to:

- Explain a real customer's business problem.
- Understand how your product fits into their workflow.
- Navigate the relevant codebase.
- Identify dependencies and escalation paths.
- Deliver a small technical change safely.
- Present a recommendation with clear trade-offs.

YOUR 30-DAY REVIEW

What did I learn? What did I ship? What remains unclear? What can I own next?

THE TAKEAWAY

Your first 30 days should build trust through learning, reliability, and small wins — not heroics.

CHAPTER 04

Scoping deployments

Most deployment problems begin before the first line of code.

A customer has an urgent problem. The founder has promised something. Sales wants it delivered quickly. Engineering has a roadmap. Everyone thinks they agree on what's being built. Until the deployment starts.

Scoping is one of the highest-leverage skills an FDE can develop because it forces assumptions into the open before they become expensive.

Start with the problem, not the requested feature

A customer might say:

“We need an AI agent that handles customer onboarding.”

That's a solution, not a clear problem statement. Ask:

- ? What does onboarding look like today?
- ? Who performs the work?
- ? Where do delays or errors occur?
- ? What existing systems are involved?
- ? What would success look like after 30 or 90 days?
- ? What happens when the AI gets something wrong?
- ? Who will operate the solution after launch?

Your job is to distinguish the desired business outcome from the proposed technical implementation.

Write a Deployment Charter

Before engineering begins, put it in writing: the business problem and why now, the success metric and current baseline, what's in scope and explicitly out of scope, dependencies, architecture, risks, acceptance criteria, ownership, milestones, and whether the work fits the agreed engagement. Then get the technical and business owners to acknowledge it.

→ Use [Template A: The Deployment Charter](#) · p.32

Example: narrowing a deployment

A financial services customer wants to automate loan processing.

TOO BROAD

"Deploy an AI system to process loans."

BETTER

"Over a four-week pilot, assist five underwriters with extracting information from one approved document type, compare results against a manually verified test set, and retain human approval of all lending decisions."

This smaller scope makes it possible to measure results without pretending the full workflow is automated. Illustrative success criteria:

- Reduce average document preparation time from 20 minutes to 10 minutes.
- Meet a customer-approved accuracy threshold on representative test cases.
- Route uncertain or incomplete outputs to human review.
- Preserve auditability and access controls.
- Obtain user sign-off before expanding.

How to manage scope changes

When a customer requests additional functionality, respond with options rather than an automatic yes.

Option A	Keep the original date and replace something else.
Option B	Expand the timeline and deliver the additional functionality.
Option C	Defer the request to a subsequent phase.

Make the consequences explicit and record the decision.

THE TAKEAWAY

A clear scope is how you protect customer trust, engineering quality, and your team's ability to deliver.

CHAPTER 05

Managing customers

Your customer doesn't just need your technical expertise. They need your judgment.

The best FDEs become trusted technical partners. That requires more than answering questions and fixing bugs. You need to understand how decisions are made, who will use the system, who can block the deployment, and what matters to each stakeholder.

Know the people around the deployment

Executive sponsor	Business value, cost, organizational risk, and timing.
Technical owner	Architecture, security, maintainability, and integration.
Operational user	Whether the solution makes their daily work easier.
Security and compliance	Access, data protection, controls, and risk.
Commercial owner	The contractual relationship, adoption, retention, or expansion.

One person might hold several roles. Make sure none are missing.

Establish a communication rhythm

Daily, during critical implementation	Blockers, decisions, technical progress.
Weekly	A stakeholder update covering milestones, risks, measurable progress, and next actions.
At every major gate	Explicit approval of scope, evaluation, production readiness, or handoff.
During incidents	A dedicated update cadence appropriate to severity.

Adjust the rhythm to the engagement. Meeting volume isn't evidence of progress.

Keep the weekly update simple and send it in the same shape every time: overall status (Green / Amber / Red), what was completed, customer impact, risks, decisions needed, and next week's priorities. Include dates, owners, and evidence wherever possible.

→ Use [Template B: The Weekly Customer Update](#) · p.33

How to establish trust

- Be honest about what the product can and cannot do.
- Explain trade-offs in business terms.
- Raise risks before they become surprises.
- Close the loop when you commit to something.
- Respect the expertise of customer engineers and operators.
- Never surprise the customer with a major architectural or timeline change.
- Document important decisions.

And don't confuse agreeing with the customer with serving the customer. Sometimes the most useful thing you can say is:

"I understand why you want that. I think there's a simpler way to achieve the same outcome, and here's why."

Being on-site

Travel is a common part of Forward Deployed Engineering, but expectations vary significantly. Some positions involve occasional customer visits. Others require substantial time on-site. The most useful question isn't how often you'll travel. It's why being there makes the deployment better.

Go when it creates value

- Early discovery and observing real customer workflows.
- Architecture and technical integration workshops.
- Working directly with customer engineers on complex blockers.
- Critical go-lives or incident preparation.
- User training and adoption.
- Executive alignment on major decisions.

Don't fly across the country to sit in video meetings from someone else's office.

Before you go

Know who needs to be in the room, what decisions need to be made, which technical blockers you can remove, what access, environments, or data must be ready, and what should be completed before everyone leaves. Share an agenda and confirm the required stakeholders are available.

While you're there

Spend time observing users, not just talking to executives. Pair directly with engineers when appropriate. Document assumptions as they're challenged. Finish every workshop with decisions, owners, and next steps.

Within one business day of leaving

Circulate key findings, technical decisions, outstanding blockers, updated milestones, and named action owners.

Protect your sustainability

Clarify travel percentage, customer coverage, expense policies, weekend expectations, and after-hours support before accepting a role. Protect recovery time, especially after demanding launches. Measure a trip by problems solved, trust built, and outcomes accelerated — not flights taken.

THE TAKEAWAY

Trust is built when your words, decisions, and execution consistently line up.

CHAPTER 06

Shipping under pressure

Move quickly. Don't create tomorrow's emergency to solve today's deadline.

Forward Deployed Engineering can be intense. Customers need answers. Production issues appear unexpectedly. Deals and launches create deadlines. Requirements change. You're expected to navigate all of it without losing technical judgment.

The answer isn't to treat every request as an emergency. It's to get exceptionally good at prioritization.

Separate urgency from importance

When everything feels urgent, assess:

Customer impact	What breaks or gets delayed if this doesn't happen?
Time sensitivity	Is there a real deadline or just a preferred one?
Risk	Could this cause security, data integrity, reliability, or financial harm?
Dependencies	Is this blocking other work?
Reversibility	Can we safely roll back if we're wrong?

Prioritize based on the consequences, not who is making the most noise.

Use the smallest safe release

When timelines are tight:

- 01 Agree on the critical outcome.
- 02 Identify the smallest safe implementation.
- 03 Remove optional features.
- 04 Address high-risk integrations early.
- 05 Test the critical path.

- 06 Deploy incrementally where possible.
- 07 Monitor outcomes.
- 08 Keep a rollback or mitigation plan ready.

NON-NEGOTIABLE

Never quietly bypass security controls or ship knowingly unsafe changes to make a deadline.

What to do when something breaks

- 01 **Assess** severity and customer impact.
- 02 **Stabilize** or mitigate the problem.
- 03 **Assign** a clear incident lead and technical ownership.
- 04 **Establish** a communication channel and update cadence.
- 05 **Investigate** root causes once the immediate risk is controlled.
- 06 **Record** lessons and preventive actions afterward.

The customer doesn't need ten engineers debating in Slack while nobody explains what's happening. They need clarity.

How to communicate a delay

BAD

"We hit some issues. Still debugging."

BETTER

"The integration is failing for a subset of records because the source data doesn't match the documented schema. We've isolated the affected path and paused the rollout. We're validating a fix now. I'll provide the next update at 2 PM with the remaining risks and a revised recommendation."

Be specific about what is known, unknown, and happening next. Don't invent an ETA.

Build repeatability

If the same emergency occurs repeatedly, improve the system. Useful investments include:

- Runbooks.
- Automated tests and deployments.
- Reusable integration patterns.
- Better logging and alerts.
- Feature flags and rollback controls.
- Templates for incident and customer communication.

THE TAKEAWAY

Speed matters. But predictable delivery, sound judgment, and recoverability matter more than looking heroic.

CHAPTER 07

Moving from pilot to production

A successful demo isn't a successful deployment.

One of the biggest problems in enterprise AI is the distance between a working proof of concept and a system that people actually use. Prototypes often run on carefully selected data, simplified environments, and generous assumptions. Production introduces unpredictable inputs, scale, security requirements, operational ownership, and real users.

Your job is to close that gap.

The five stages of deployment maturity

01	Discovery	The problem and expected business outcome are understood.
02	Prototype examples.	Technical feasibility has been demonstrated using representative
03	Pilot	Real users validate the solution against explicit success criteria within a controlled scope.
04	Production	The system meets operational, security, reliability, and support requirements and is available in the agreed live environment.
05	Adoption and scale	The solution is consistently used, measured, maintained, and expanded where results justify it.

Don't skip from "the demo worked" to "let's launch it everywhere."

Your production readiness checklist

BUSINESS READINESS

- ☐ The customer agrees on the problem, baseline, and success criteria.
- ☐ Pilot outcomes are measured, not anecdotal.
- ☐ The business owner approves deployment.

TECHNICAL READINESS

- ☐ The architecture handles expected production load.
- ☐ Integrations and failure paths have been tested.
- ☐ Logging, monitoring, and alerting are functioning.
- ☐ Latency and operating costs are within agreed limits.
- ☐ Rollback and recovery processes are documented.

AI-SPECIFIC READINESS, WHERE APPLICABLE

- ☐ Evaluations cover representative real-world inputs.
- ☐ Important failure modes and edge cases are tested.
- ☐ Model, prompt, and evaluation versions are tracked.
- ☐ Incorrect or uncertain outputs have defined handling.
- ☐ High-impact actions have appropriate human approvals and controls.

SECURITY READINESS

- ☐ Data access follows least-privilege principles.
- ☐ Secrets and credentials are appropriately managed.
- ☐ Logging and data retention meet customer requirements.
- ☐ Necessary security, privacy, and compliance reviews are complete.

OPERATIONAL READINESS

- ☐ An owner is responsible for ongoing operation.
- ☐ Incident response and escalation paths are documented.
- ☐ Support teams can troubleshoot the system.
- ☐ Runbooks and handoff documentation are complete.

ADOPTION READINESS

- ☐ Real users have been trained.
- ☐ Someone owns onboarding and change management.
- ☐ Usage and business outcomes can be measured.
- ☐ The customer has an agreed expansion or improvement plan.

Measure outcomes, not just deployments

Technical health	Availability, error rate, latency, quality, and cost.
Adoption	Active users, workflow coverage, repeated usage, and human override or abandonment rates.
Business impact	Time saved, errors reduced, throughput increased, or other agreed customer metrics.

Time saved per workflow multiplied by volume is a ceiling, not a result. Only call it realized value after checking actual volume, review and rework time, quality, and the customer's operating costs.

Make the go/no-go decision explicit

Production readiness should be a documented decision, not the consequence of a deadline.

Go	All critical requirements are satisfied.
Conditional go	A limited rollout is approved with documented safeguards and owners.
No-go	Unacceptable risks or missing evidence remain.

→ Use [Template C: Production Go/No-Go · p.34](#)

THE TAKEAWAY

The deployment isn't finished when your code goes live. It's successful when the customer can reliably use it and demonstrate value.

CHAPTER 08

Handling difficult stakeholders

The difficult conversation is often the most valuable one.

Not every customer relationship is straightforward. You'll work with demanding executives, skeptical engineers, changing requirements, organizational politics, and conflicting priorities. Avoiding those conversations usually makes them worse.

01 The customer wants something unrealistic. Explain the trade-off. Offer a solution.

"I understand what you're trying to achieve. The current timeline doesn't support delivering that full scope safely. We can deliver the critical workflow by Friday, or the broader functionality with more time. Here's what I recommend."

02 Sales promised something that isn't available. Don't throw Sales under the bus or make commitments on behalf of Product. Confirm what was promised, identify what is technically supported, and align internally before presenting the customer with a realistic plan. Your job is to repair the expectation, not win an argument.

03 The customer's engineering team doesn't trust your solution. Invite them into the design. Ask what concerns them about maintainability, security, performance, or operational ownership. Present the evidence behind your decisions and change the plan when they identify a legitimate problem. Their skepticism may save you from a production incident.

04 Stakeholders keep changing their minds. Return to the agreed business outcome. Record decisions and identify the person authorized to approve scope changes. If priorities change, document what will be delayed, removed, or replaced.

The disagreement framework

01	02	03	04	05
Acknowledge	Clarify	Explain	Recommend	Confirm
Show you understand the concern.	Confirm the outcome they're trying to achieve.	Present the technical or operational trade-off.	Offer a concrete path forward.	Agree on the decision and owner.

Escalate when decisions threaten safety, contractual obligations, or delivery and cannot be resolved at the working-team level.

THE TAKEAWAY

Strong FDEs aren't afraid of disagreement. They make difficult decisions easier for everyone involved.

CHAPTER 09

Career progression

The next level isn't about how many customers you can juggle.

Strong FDEs build technical depth, customer judgment, and delivery ownership. Great FDEs make the entire organization more effective. Career progression differs by employer, but a useful framework looks like this:

Early-career FDE

LEARN AND DELIVER WITH SUPPORT

- Build technical fundamentals.
- Contribute to real deployments.
- Understand customer workflows.
- Develop communication and debugging skills.
- Take ownership of small technical problems.

Mid-level FDE

INDEPENDENTLY OWN DELIVERY

- Lead scoped deployments.
- Manage technical ambiguity.
- Communicate directly with customers.
- Make sensible architecture decisions.
- Resolve blockers without constant escalation.

Senior FDE

OWN COMPLEX OUTCOMES

- Lead high-stakes or multi-system deployments.
- Navigate difficult stakeholders.
- Mentor junior engineers.
- Improve delivery practices.
- Influence product decisions through field evidence.

Staff or Principal FDE

CREATE LEVERAGE ACROSS TEAMS

- Solve novel, cross-customer problems.
- Establish reference architectures.
- Influence technical strategy.
- Build reusable systems and frameworks.
- Raise engineering and delivery standards.

FDE Manager or Deployment Lead

SCALE RESULTS THROUGH PEOPLE AND SYSTEMS

- Hire and develop strong FDEs.
- Allocate resources across deployments.
- Own delivery quality and outcomes.
- Manage organizational and customer escalations.
- Build repeatable operating practices.

Leadership doesn't automatically mean management. Senior individual contributors can have enormous impact without direct reports.

How to demonstrate impact

Stop describing your performance only in terms of features shipped or customers supported. Start documenting:

- Business outcomes delivered.
- Production deployments completed.
- Adoption and reliability improvements.
- Technical complexity resolved.
- Reusable components created.
- Customer escalations prevented or addressed.
- Engineers mentored.
- Product decisions influenced.

Keep a short impact log and update it monthly.

THE TAKEAWAY

Progress from delivering work, to owning outcomes, to improving how everyone else delivers outcomes.

CHAPTER 10

Compensation

Understand what you're being paid for — and what you're actually being offered.

Forward Deployed Engineering sits between several competitive talent markets: software engineering, AI engineering, specialized deployment work, and customer-facing technical leadership. That makes compensation difficult to benchmark using a single generic title.

A company hiring an FDE to support straightforward integrations may be looking for something very different from one hiring an engineer to own complex enterprise AI deployments.

Evaluate the complete package

Base salary	What you receive regardless of performance.
Cash bonus	Target payout, performance conditions, and how frequently it has historically been paid.
Equity	Type of award, number of shares, vesting schedule, dilution risk, strike price where relevant, and liquidity prospects.
Benefits	Healthcare, retirement contributions, leave, relocation, and other meaningful costs.
Role scope	Number of accounts, deployment complexity, travel, working hours, and operational support.
Career upside	Leadership, mentorship, learning opportunities, and potential progression.

How to evaluate startup equity

Ask questions before assigning equity a value:

- ? Are these stock options, RSUs, or another security?
- ? How many shares or units will I receive?
- ? What percentage of fully diluted ownership do they represent, if applicable?
- ? What is the vesting schedule?
- ? What are the strike price and exercise terms for options?

- ? What financing preferences or other rights could affect outcomes?
- ? What is the realistic path to liquidity?
- ? What happens if I leave?
- ? Are refresh grants part of the compensation philosophy?

A headline valuation is not the same thing as money you'll receive.

How to negotiate

Focus on the combination of scarcity, technical capability, customer ownership, and business impact you bring. Where possible, use genuinely comparable offers and current hiring competition rather than relying entirely on compensation survey percentiles.

But don't assume a published top-of-range salary is attainable for every candidate. A strong negotiation explains why your experience maps to the specific scope and level of the role.

What founders should understand

You're not only competing with other companies using the FDE title. You may be competing for the same person as a software engineering team, AI startup, infrastructure company, or technical founding team.

Define what you need that engineer to accomplish before establishing the compensation range.

THE TAKEAWAY

Benchmark the work, the level, and the competing opportunities — not just the title.

CHAPTER 11

Building an FDE organization

Hiring five great engineers doesn't automatically give you a great deployment team.

As enterprise deployments become more complex, founders need to think carefully about what their FDE organization exists to accomplish. Is the team responsible for proving technical value? Building custom production systems? Accelerating enterprise adoption? Influencing the core product? Supporting implementation revenue? Or some combination?

The answer determines who you hire, how you structure the team, and what success looks like.

STEP 01 Define the charter

Write down the FDE organization's responsibilities. A starting charter:

"Our FDE team owns the technical delivery of strategic customer deployments, from discovery and solution design through implementation, production readiness, and measurable adoption. It develops reusable patterns and provides structured feedback to Product and Engineering."

Then define the boundaries. For example:

FDE	Customer-specific architecture, hands-on implementation, technical delivery.
Solutions Engineering	Technical discovery and pre-sales validation, where a separate team exists.
Core Engineering	Shared product capabilities, platform reliability, productized functionality.
Customer Success	Relationship health, adoption coordination, renewal strategy, where applicable.
Support / SRE	Ongoing support and incident responsibilities under the agreed operating model.

Smaller organizations may combine several functions. The dangerous situation is when nobody knows who's accountable for production.

STEP 02 Hire for the actual job

Assess five capabilities, and score them in every interview with the same weights.

Production engineering	Can the candidate build, debug, design integrations, and safely deploy software?	25%
Problem decomposition and scoping	Can they turn ambiguity into a realistic, scoped technical plan?	20%
Customer communication	Can they work credibly with engineers, operators, and executives?	20%
Ownership and judgment	Do they drive work forward without perfect information, prioritize, handle risk, and make good trade-offs?	20%
Learning and leverage	Can they adapt quickly and turn repeated problems into reusable solutions?	15%

STEP 03 Use a structured interview process

- 01 **Technical and ownership screen.** Review real projects, depth of engineering contribution, and examples of ambiguity.
- 02 **Practical coding.** Test production-oriented coding, debugging, or extending an unfamiliar codebase.
- 03 **Deployment case.** Give the candidate a vague customer problem and ask them to conduct discovery, scope an MVP, and explain a technical solution.
- 04 **Stakeholder scenario.** Assess trade-offs, difficult conversations, and delivery pressure.
- 05 **Team debrief.** Compare independent evidence against the rubric before reaching a decision.

Score every candidate against the five capabilities in Step 2, using the suggested weights. Rate each one 1–4:

1 below the bar · 2 developing · 3 meets the role requirement · 4 substantially exceeds it

Set explicit minimum bars for safety-critical capabilities, and don't let a high overall score conceal a serious weakness.

→ Use [Template D: FDE Interview Scorecard](#) · p.35

STEP 04 Create an operating model

For each deployment, establish:

- A technical owner.
- A business outcome owner.
- A documented scope.
- A shared milestone plan.
- A risk and dependency register.
- An agreed customer communication rhythm.
- A production acceptance and handoff process.

Avoid assigning unlimited customers to each engineer simply because workloads initially look manageable. Staff around complexity, integration risk, customer capability, and delivery phase — not a universal number of accounts per FDE.

STEP 05 Measure the right things

A useful FDE scorecard covers four dimensions.

DELIVERY

- ☐ Time from technical kickoff to first value.
- ☐ Milestone reliability.
- ☐ Deployment cycle time.
- ☐ Rework and reopened issues.

ENGINEERING QUALITY

- ☐ Reliability and incident severity.
- ☐ Failed deployments and recovery performance.
- ☐ Security and operational readiness.
- ☐ Maintainability and technical debt.

CUSTOMER OUTCOMES

- ☐ Production adoption.
- ☐ Business KPIs achieved.
- ☐ User engagement and workflow coverage.
- ☐ Customer-reported quality.

ORGANIZATIONAL LEVERAGE

- ☐ Reusable components adopted.
- ☐ Recurring problems eliminated.
- ☐ Product improvements informed by field evidence.
- ☐ Engineer onboarding and mentoring effectiveness.

Don't reward speed at the expense of reliability or encourage teams to inflate adoption metrics.

STEP 06 Build the feedback loop

Every customer deployment teaches you something about the product. Create a simple classification:

Customer-specific	Solved locally because the requirement is unique.
Repeatable pattern	A solution that should be reused across deployments.
Core product gap	A recurring issue that should be owned by Product or Engineering.

Review the patterns regularly with technical and product leadership. The goal is to reduce repeated custom work without losing the ability to solve novel customer problems.

STEP 07 **Create a real development path**

Junior engineers need supported opportunities to learn from customer work. Pair them with experienced FDEs. Let them observe technical discovery. Give them bounded production responsibilities. Review their scoping and decision-making. Make space for incident reviews and internal technical demonstrations.

If you only hire people who have already completed complex FDE deployments, your organization may eventually run out of people to recruit.

THE TAKEAWAY

The strongest FDE organizations don't just deliver more deployments. They become better at delivering every subsequent one.

THE DEPLOYMENT TOOLKIT

Templates worth saving

Starting points, not rules. Adapt them to your organization's approval processes, security requirements, and customer agreements.

A	The Deployment Charter	32
	Scope a deployment before engineering begins. Pairs with Chapter 04.	
B	The Weekly Customer Update	33
	One consistent shape for status, risks, and decisions. Pairs with Chapter 05.	
C	Production Go/No-Go	34
	Make readiness a documented decision. Pairs with Chapter 07.	
D	FDE Interview Scorecard	35
	Score candidates against the same five competencies. Pairs with Chapter 11.	

TEMPLATE A

CHAPTER 04

The Deployment Charter

Complete before engineering begins. Get the technical and business owners to sign off.

PROJECT

CUSTOMER / PROJECT

DEPLOYMENT OWNER

CUSTOMER TECHNICAL OWNER

EXECUTIVE / BUSINESS SPONSOR

THE PROBLEM

PROBLEM STATEMENT • WHAT, FOR WHOM, WHY NOW

CURRENT PROCESS AND BASELINE

TARGET BUSINESS OUTCOME

SUCCESS METRICS AND ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

SCOPE

IN SCOPE

OUT OF SCOPE

DATA AND SYSTEM DEPENDENCIES

SECURITY / COMPLIANCE REQUIREMENTS

TECHNICAL APPROACH

DELIVERY

MAJOR RISKS

MILESTONES AND TARGET DATES

DECISIONS NEEDED

COMMERCIAL ALIGNMENT

PRODUCTION OWNER AND SUPPORT MODEL

APPROVAL / SIGN-OFF

TEMPLATE B

CHAPTER 05

The Weekly Customer Update

Same shape every week. Include dates, owners, and evidence wherever possible.

PROJECT

WEEK ENDING

OVERALL STATUS

☐ Green ☐ Amber ☐ Red

WHAT WE COMPLETED

MEASURED PROGRESS / CUSTOMER IMPACT

RISKS AND BLOCKERS

RISK

OWNER

IMPACT

MITIGATION

DECISIONS REQUIRED

DECISION

DECISION-MAKER

DEADLINE

NEXT WEEK'S PRIORITIES

CHANGES TO TIMELINE OR SCOPE

NEXT UPDATE

TEMPLATE C

CHAPTER 07

Production Go/No-Go

Readiness is a documented decision, not the consequence of a deadline.

PROJECT / RELEASE

TARGET DEPLOYMENT DATE

READINESS AREA

PASS

COND.

FAIL

Business success criteria met

☐☐☐

Technical tests completed

☐☐☐

Relevant AI evaluations passed

☐☐☐

Performance and cost validated

☐☐☐

Security approvals completed

☐☐☐

Monitoring and alerting operational

☐☐☐

Rollback and recovery tested

☐☐☐

Support ownership confirmed

☐☐☐

User training completed

☐☐☐

Known risks documented

☐☐☐

OPEN ISSUES

MITIGATIONS AND OWNERS

DECISION

☐ Go ☐ Conditional go ☐ No-go

APPROVER(S)

NEXT REVIEW DATE, IF APPLICABLE

TEMPLATE D

CHAPTER 11

FDE Interview Scorecard

Score each competency 1–4 independently, before the team debrief.

CANDIDATE	ROLE / LEVEL	INTERVIEWER
COMPETENCY	WEIGHT	SCORE
Production engineering	25%	1 2 3 4
Problem decomposition and scoping	20%	1 2 3 4
Customer communication	20%	1 2 3 4
Ownership and judgment	20%	1 2 3 4
Learning and leverage	15%	1 2 3 4

EVIDENCE

TECHNICAL

CUSTOMER AND COMMUNICATION

LEARNING AND LEVERAGE

PROBLEM DECOMPOSITION

OWNERSHIP AND JUDGMENT

AREAS OF CONCERN

RECOMMENDATION

☐ Strong hire
 ☐ Hire
 ☐ No hire
 ☐ Strong no hire

EVIDENCE SUPPORTING RECOMMENDATION

OPEN QUESTIONS FOR TEAM DEBRIEF

Great deployment engineers do more than write code.

-
- 01 They understand problems before proposing solutions.
 - 02 They take responsibility for outcomes.
 - 03 They treat customer trust as something earned.
 - 04 They communicate clearly, especially when things go wrong.
 - 05 They know when to move fast and when to slow down.
 - 06 They build systems people can actually operate.
 - 07 And they share what they've learned.
-

Because the future of Forward Deployed Engineering shouldn't depend on everyone figuring it out alone.